

Composing Poetry

Knowing how to analyze a poem and being able to write one are two different skills. One can identify a sonnet's rhyme scheme, trace a free verse poem's imagery, or admire a spoken word poet's delivery. But sitting down to write one's own poem is another challenge entirely. Where does one begin? How does a writer choose between a sonnet and free verse? How does one borrow inspiration from studied poets without copying them? These are the questions that poets grapple with every day.

Creative writing is the practice of shaping language into art. Writing poetry requires selecting appropriate forms, applying feedback through revision, incorporating inspiration from studied works while maintaining original expression, and adapting delivery for different audiences. This lesson moves from analysis to action. It guides writers through the process of composing original poems.

This reading material explains how to compose original poems by selecting appropriate forms (such as free verse, sonnet, and spoken word). It describes how to apply self-assessment, peer, and teacher feedback in revising drafts for coherence, impact, and ethical representation. It discusses how to incorporate ideas or inspiration from studied works and poets while maintaining original expression. Finally, it explains how to adapt different forms of delivery (bimodal or multimodal) and platforms to present one's own poems to various audiences.

Part 1: Selecting Appropriate Poetic Forms

Before writing a poem, a poet must choose a form. The form should serve the poem's purpose, subject, and intended emotional effect. Different forms offer different possibilities.

Overview of Poetic Forms for Composition

Form	Key Features	Best For	Example
Free verse	No regular meter or rhyme; uses line breaks, white space, and imagery	Natural speech, personal reflection, contemporary subjects	William Carlos Williams, "This Is Just to Say"
Sonnet	14 lines, iambic pentameter, specific rhyme scheme (Shakespearean or Petrarchan)	Love, longing, formal reflection, argument with a turn (volta)	Shakespeare, "Sonnet 18"
Spoken word / performance poetry	Written for oral delivery; uses repetition, rhythm, audience address	Social commentary, personal testimony, emotional intensity	Sarah Kay, "B"
Haiku	3 lines, syllable pattern 5-7-5, often nature-themed	Moments of observation, stillness, simplicity	Matsuo Bashō
Villanelle	19 lines, two repeating rhymes, two refrains	Obsession, grief, inescapable thoughts	Dylan Thomas, "Do not go gentle into that good night"
Prose poem	Written in paragraph form, no line breaks; uses poetic language	Blurring poetry and prose, narrative meditation	Claudia Rankine, "Citizen"
Lyric poem	Short, musical, expresses personal emotion	Intense feeling, subjective experience	John Keats, "Ode to a Nightingale"

How to Choose a Form

Question to Ask	If Yes, Consider This Form
Do you want to write about intense personal emotion?	Lyric poem or sonnet
Do you want to sound like natural speech?	Free verse
Do you want to perform the poem aloud?	Spoken word
Do you want to capture a single, quiet moment?	Haiku
Do you want to explore an obsessive or repeating thought?	Villanelle
Do you want to blur poetry and storytelling?	Prose poem

Experimenting with Form: A Starting Point

Step	Action
1	Choose a subject (a memory, an observation, a feeling, a question)
2	Write a free write (no rules, just get words on the page)
3	Decide what emotional effect you want
4	Select a form that serves that effect
5	Shape your free write into the chosen form

Part 2: How to Write Your Poem: A Step-by-Step Guide

Writing a poem can feel mysterious, but it does not have to be. The process can be broken down into manageable steps. Following these steps will help any writer move from a blank page to a completed draft.

Step One: Find a Starting Point

A poem can begin anywhere: a memory that will not fade, an image that caught your attention, a question you cannot answer, or a feeling you cannot name. Some poets start with a single line that arrives unbidden. Others start with a subject they want to explore, such as a childhood home, a lost relative, or a political anger. Do not worry about whether the starting point is "poetic." It just needs to be yours.

Step Two: Free Write Without Rules

Once you have a starting point, write for five to ten minutes without stopping. Do not worry about line breaks, rhyme, grammar, or punctuation. Do not cross anything out. If you get stuck, write the same word over and over until a new thought comes. The goal of this step is quantity, not quality. You cannot shape a poem from nothing, but you can shape a poem from messy raw material.

Step Three: Identify the Emotional Core

Read your free write. What emotion is at the center? Grief? Joy? Longing? Confusion? Anger? Nostalgia? Underline any words or phrases that carry that emotion. Circle any images that feel vivid. The emotional core of the poem is what you want the reader to feel. Every decision you make later – line breaks, word choice, form – should serve that emotional core.

Step Four: Choose a Form

Decide which form will best serve your emotional core. If you want to sound like natural speech and experiment freely, choose free verse. If you want to write about love or longing with a formal turn (volta), consider a sonnet. If you want to perform the poem aloud for an audience, choose spoken word. If you want to capture a single quiet moment, try a haiku. Do not force a form onto a subject that resists it. The form should feel like an ally, not a cage.

Step Five: Shape the Raw Material into Lines

Now take your free write and begin breaking it into lines. Read the poem aloud as you do this. Where your voice naturally pauses, consider a line break. Where you want the reader to pause or feel emphasis, break earlier. Where you want speed and flow, break later or use enjambment (carrying a sentence from one line to the next without punctuation). Pay attention to the last word of each line – that word receives special emphasis.

Step Six: Add and Subtract

Read your draft. Circle any vague words (sad, beautiful, nice, bad, happy). Replace them with specific, concrete images. If you wrote "I was sad," replace it with "My reflection in the spoon stretched like a scream." If you wrote "The house was old," replace it with "The linoleum curled at the edges, yellowed by decades of cigarette smoke." At the same time, cut any words that do nothing. Every word in a poem must earn its place.

Step Seven: Read Aloud and Revise

Poetry is sound. Read your draft aloud at least three times. Listen for rhythm. Where do you stumble? Revise those spots. Where does the language sing? Keep those spots. Notice your breathing. Line breaks should respect natural breath pauses. Ask someone else to read the poem aloud to you. Hearing it in another voice reveals problems your own ear might miss.

Step Eight: Title the Poem

Do not simply name the subject ("My Grandmother," "Nature," "Love"). A good title does work. It can establish a situation ("The Morning After the Fire"), create mystery ("The Thing You Never Asked"), or echo a key phrase from the poem. Some poets write the title last, after they know what the poem is truly about.

Step Nine: Let the Poem Rest

Set the poem aside for a day or two. Do not look at it. When you return, you will see it with fresh eyes. You will notice clichés you missed, lines that need cutting, and images that deserve more space. Final revision is always easier after distance.

Step Ten: Decide How to Share

Once the poem is revised, decide where and how to share it. Will you submit it to a literary magazine? Perform it at an open mic? Post it on Instagram? Record it for a

podcast? Each audience requires different preparation. A poem that works on the page may need adaptation for the stage or screen.

Part 3: Incorporating Ideas from Studied Works While Maintaining Original Expression

Poets do not write in a vacuum. They read other poets. They are influenced by what they read. The key is to **transform** inspiration into something new – not to copy.

Acceptable vs. Unacceptable Borrowing

Practice	Acceptable?	How to Do It Ethically
Reading widely for inspiration	Yes	Keep a reading journal; note what you admire
Using a traditional form (sonnet, haiku)	Yes	Forms are public domain
Echoing a phrase or image as homage	Yes, if transformed	Change the subject, context, or perspective
Writing a response poem	Yes	Title it "After [Poet's Name]" or include an epigraph
Copying a line without attribution	No	This is plagiarism
Changing a few words of an existing poem	No	This is still plagiarism

Techniques for Transforming Inspiration

Technique	What It Does	Example
Change the subject	Take a poet's style or structure and apply it to a different subject	Write a nature poem in the style of a political poet
Change the perspective	Write from a different point of view	Respond to a poem written by a man from a woman's perspective
Change the setting	Move the poem to a different time or place	Take an urban poem and set it in a rural landscape
Combine influences	Blend techniques from two or more poets	Use Dickinson's dashes with Whitman's long lines
Write an homage	Title your poem "After [Poet's Name]" to signal your debt	"Homage to My Hips" (Lucille Clifton echoes Whitman)

Sample: Inspiration Transformed

Studied Poem	Feature Borrowed	Original Poem	Transformation
William Carlos Williams, "This Is Just Say" (free verse, apology for eating plums)	Direct address, mundane subject, free verse	Poem apologizing for losing a library book	Same form, different subject
Shakespeare, Sonnet 18 ("Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?")	Sonnet form, comparison conceit, volta at line 9	Sonnet comparing a parent to a winter storm	Same form, different comparison, different tone

Maintaining Original Expression

Guideline	Explanation
Use your own details	Borrow a structure, but fill it with your specific memories, observations, and language
Write about what only you know	No one else has lived your life; your specific experiences are your original material
Avoid clichés	If you have heard a phrase before (e.g., "fit as a fiddle," "dark as night"), find a fresh way to say it
Trust your voice	Do not try to sound like a famous poet. Sound like yourself.

Part 4: Applying Feedback in Revising Poems

Poems are rarely perfect in the first draft. Revision is where a poem transforms from raw material into art. Feedback from self, peers, and teachers is essential.

Three Types of Feedback

Type of Feedback	Source	Purpose
Self-assessment	The poet	Identifying strengths, weaknesses, and areas for revision
Peer feedback	Classmates	Gaining fresh perspective from readers
Teacher feedback	Instructor	Receiving expert guidance on craft and form

Self-Assessment Questions for Poetry Revision

Question	Focus
Is the form appropriate for the subject?	Coherence of form and content
Does every word earn its place?	Concision
Are the images fresh and specific?	Originality
Where is the emotional core of the poem?	Impact
Have I represented any real people ethically?	Ethical representation
Does the ending land (not just stop)?	Closure

Peer Feedback Protocol for Poetry

Step	Action
1	Poet shares draft and specifies what feedback is needed (e.g., "Please focus on imagery and the ending.")
2	Peer reads the poem aloud (poetry is meant to be heard)
3	Peer provides feedback using the "Praise – Question – Suggest" model
4	Poet listens without defending or explaining
5	Poet thanks peer and decides later which feedback to use

The Praise – Question – Suggest Model for Poetry:

Element	What to Say	Example
Praise	What is working well	"The opening image of the cracked teacup is stunning."
Question	What confuses or intrigues	"Why does the speaker mention the rain twice?"
Suggest	One specific improvement	"Consider cutting the third stanza – it tells what the images already show."

Teacher Feedback: What to Expect

Focus Area	What the Teacher Assesses
Form	Is the chosen form used appropriately and effectively?
Language	Are diction, imagery, and sound devices working together?
Coherence	Does the poem hold together? Is every part serving the whole?
Impact	Does the poem evoke emotion or provoke thought?
Ethical representation	Are real people represented fairly? Is the poem honest without being cruel?

Revision Checklist for Poems

Check	What to Look For
Line breaks	Read aloud. Do the breaks emphasize the right words? Try breaking in different places.

Check	What to Look For
Word choice	Replace vague words (nice, sad, beautiful) with specific, concrete words.
Clichés	Find and replace any phrase you have heard before.
Showing vs. telling	Circle abstract statements (I was angry). Replace with concrete images (My fist found the wall).
Ending	Does the poem end with an image, a turn, or a surprise – not just a stop?
Title	Does the title do work? It should not just name the subject.

Part 5: Ethical Representation in Poetry

Because poetry may draw from real life – memories, relationships, observations – poets have an ethical responsibility to the people they write about.

Ethical Principles for Poets

Principle	What It Means
Do not harm	Avoid unnecessary cruelty or exposure of private information
Change identifying details	If a poem could embarrass or hurt someone, change their name or characteristics
Be honest about memory	If you are unsure of details, use phrases like "I remember" or "Perhaps"
Consider consent	For sensitive poems about others, consider showing them the draft

Principle	What It Means
Write yourself with honesty	Do not make yourself the hero or the victim unfairly; be honest about your own flaws

Ethical Questions to Ask Before Sharing a Poem

Would I read this poem aloud to the person it describes?

Have I changed enough details to protect privacy?

Am I being honest about my own role, not just blaming others?

Does this poem serve the truth or just my ego?

Part 6: Adapting Delivery and Platforms for Different Audiences

Once a poem is written and revised, the poet must decide how to share it. Different audiences and platforms require different forms of delivery.

Bimodal and Multimodal Delivery

Term	Definition	Examples
Bimodal	Delivery using two modes of communication	Printed text + spoken reading; text + image
Multimodal	Delivery using three or more modes	Text + spoken audio + music + video

Platforms and Formats for Presenting Poetry

Platform/Format	Best For	Considerations
Printed page (literary magazine, chapbook)	Traditional publication, contests	Reader sees line breaks and white space; silent reading
Live spoken word / poetry slam	Immediate emotional impact, performance	Requires vocal delivery, eye contact, physical presence
Audio recording (podcast, voice note)	Intimate listening; online sharing	Voice alone carries the emotion; music optional
Video poem (YouTube, Instagram, TikTok)	Visual storytelling, younger audiences	Combine spoken word with images, text overlays, music
Social media (Instagram caption, Twitter thread)	Short poems, wide reach	Extreme concision; visual element (photo) often included
Digital / kinetic poetry (website, app)	Interactive, experimental	Text moves, appears, disappears; reader may click or scroll

Adapting the Same Poem for Different Audiences

Audience	Adaptation Strategy
Academic (teacher, literary journal)	Preserve complexity and craft; follow submission guidelines
General public (social media)	Shorten; add visual element; lead with strongest line
Live audience (poetry slam)	Emphasize repetition, rhythm, and vocal cues; practice delivery
Podcast listeners	Focus on sound and pacing; words alone must carry meaning

Audience

Adaptation Strategy

Family members (sensitive subjects)

Consider ethical representation carefully; you may need to change names or details

Tips for Performing Spoken Word Poetry

Tip

Explanation

Memorize the poem

Eye contact with the audience is powerful

Use your breath

Pause at line breaks; breathe at punctuation

Vary your pace

Speed up for urgency; slow down for emphasis

Project your voice

Speak to the back of the room

Trust the silence

Do not fill pauses with filler words (um, like)

Record yourself

Listen back to hear what works

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Free verse	Poetry with no regular meter or required rhyme
Sonnet	14-line poem with iambic pentameter and a specific rhyme scheme
Spoken word	Poetry written for oral performance
Villanelle	19-line poem with two repeating rhymes and two refrains
Prose poem	Poetry written in paragraph form without line breaks
Lyric poem	Short, musical poem expressing personal emotion
Homage	A work written in respectful tribute to another writer
Transformation	Changing borrowed material (subject, perspective, setting) to make it original
Bimodal delivery	Using two modes of communication (e.g., text + audio)
Multimodal delivery	Using three or more modes of communication (e.g., text + audio + video)
Ethical representation	Representing real people fairly, respectfully, and without unnecessary harm

Review Questions

1. List three poetic forms (e.g., free verse, sonnet, spoken word). For each form, state one key structural feature and one type of subject or emotion it is best suited for.
2. What is the difference between acceptable borrowing and plagiarism in poetry? Provide one example of each.
3. Describe two techniques for transforming inspiration from a studied poem into an original work. Provide an original example for each technique (imagined, not copied).
4. What are three questions a poet should ask themselves during self-assessment when revising a poem?
5. Explain the "Praise – Question – Suggest" model for peer feedback. What is the purpose of each element?
6. List three ethical principles a poet should follow when writing about real people. Why is each principle important?
7. Define bimodal and multimodal delivery. Describe two different platforms for presenting poetry, and explain what kind of audience each platform best serves.
8. A student writes a poem inspired by Shakespeare's Sonnet 18 but changes the comparison (summer's day → winter storm) and the subject (beloved → a grandparent). Is this acceptable borrowing or plagiarism? Explain your reasoning.
9. What are three tips for performing spoken word poetry effectively?
10. Application question: You have written a poem about a difficult memory involving a family member. You want to share it in three different contexts: a classroom peer feedback session, a public spoken word open mic night, and an Instagram post. Describe how you would adapt the poem (or your delivery) for each audience. What would you keep the same? What would you change? What ethical considerations would you keep in mind?